

names of businesses or individuals who have obtained a copy of your credit report are also included. In addition, your report contains information obtained from public records, such as your job history, whether you own your home, and whether you've been sued, arrested, or have filed for bankruptcy.

When issues between you and a creditor can't be resolved, the comments and explanations you're allowed to add to your credit report and the creditor's response to your statements become part of your credit report. If an account was turned over to a collection agency, your report will include it as a "collection account" until it's paid in full; then it will be noted as a "paid collection," and will stay on your credit report for seven years from the date of the first missed payment.

Review Your Credit Report

Financial advisors recommend that you obtain a copy of your credit report at least once a year and review it carefully. The Fair Credit Reporting Act allows you to get one free credit report from each credit-reporting company every year. If you've been turned down for credit, housing, or employment because of information in your report, you may be entitled to an additional free copy of your credit report. Some states require that credit bureaus provide free copies or charge a reduced price for residents of that state, so you may find a variety of ways to get more than one free credit report per year from each of the credit-reporting companies.



Your credit report does *not* include information about your race or national origin, religion, personal lifestyle, political affiliation, medical history, criminal record, or other information unrelated to your credit history and ability to repay debt.
